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AKBAR'S "HOUSE OF WORSHIP", OR 'IBADAT-KHANA

By VINCENT A. SMITH

ONE of the most famous institutions of Akbar was the 'Ibādat-khāna, or "House of Worship", which he caused to be erected early in 1575, immediately after his return from the successful siege of Patna. The building no longer exists above ground, although it is just possible that its foundations may be still traceable, if searched for in the right locality. The two suggestions published concerning its situation, which will be noticed near the end of this paper, are both inadmissible, as will appear from perusal of the texts which I proceed to quote from Badāonī, the *Ṭabaḳāt-i-Akbarī*, and the *Akbarnāma*, all contemporary authorities.

Badāonī relates that at the time in question, when Akbar was at leisure from war, his thoughts turned continually to the problems of religion.

"His Majesty spent whole nights in praising God, . . . and from a feeling of thankfulness for his past successes he would sit many a morning alone in prayer and meditation on a large flat stone of an old building which lay near the palace in a lonely spot, with his head bent over his chest, gathering the bliss of the early hours of dawn."

Stimulated by the example of Sulaimān Kirānī, the late ruler of Bengal, who used to spend whole nights with a hundred and fifty holy men, "listening to commentaries and exhortations," and also by the expectation of receiving Mirzā Sulaimān of Badakhshān, who was a Sūfi with an equally strong taste for theological discussion, Akbar resolved to provide a debating hall suitable for the accommodation of a large number of Muslim theologians of all types.

For those reasons he caused to be repaired or rebuilt the disused cell of Shaikh Abdullah Niyāzī of Sirhind, a former disciple of Shaikh Salīm Chishtī, and

"built a spacious hall on all four sides of it. He also finished the construction of the tank called Anūptalāo.¹

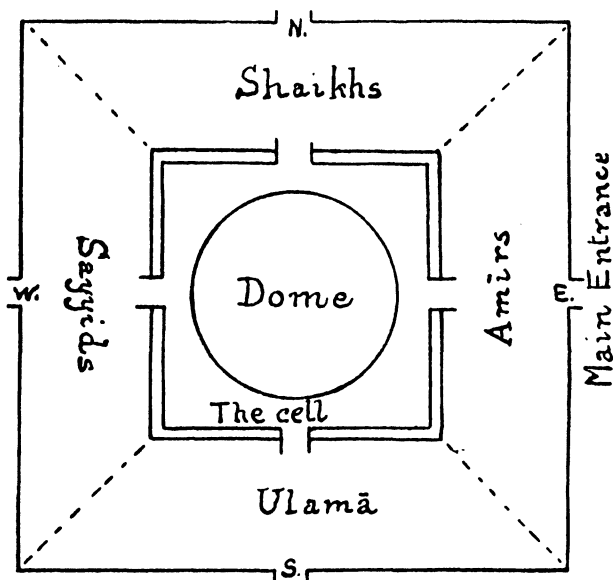
"He named that cell the *Ibādat-khānah* . . . On Fridays after prayers he would go from the new chapel (*khankāh*) of the Shaikh-ul-Islām [*scil.* Salīm Chishtī, who had died in February, 1572, a few months after the completion of the great mosque], and hold a meeting in this building—Shaikhs [*scil.* members of the Muslim ascetic orders], 'Ulamā [or doctors learned in the religious law], and pious men, and a few of his own companions and attendants were the only people who were invited . . . The Emperor . . . sent for Shaikh Zīyā-ullāh with a view to showing him kindness. He assembled a party in his honour at the *Ibādat-khāna*, and every Thursday evening he invited Sayyids, Shaikhs, 'Ulamā, and Amīrs [or nobles of the court]. But ill-feeling arose in the company about the seats and order of precedence, so His Majesty ordered that the Amīrs should sit on the east side, the Sayyids on the west, the 'Ulamā on the south, and the Shaikhs on the north. His Majesty would go from time to time to these various parties, and converse with them and discuss philosophical subjects."²

That account, written by an author who was often present at the discussions, proves that the building was a large one, built round the "cell" as repaired or rebuilt, which probably was a small domed structure. The hall or main chamber must have been a single room, because at the early meetings all classes were mixed up, and they were not sorted out so as to sit on special sides until disputes about their placing had arisen. Akbar could move about freely from any one side to another. The

¹ On one occasion Akbar invited a few Ulamā to hold a debate against Abu-l-Fazl "at the house near the Anūptalāo tank". That house seems to have been distinct from the *Ibādat-khāna*. At any rate there is no evidence that the two names refer to the one building.

² *Muntakhabu-t tawārikh*, tr. Lowe, ii, 203-5, with corrections as on p. vii.

description suggests a plan such as this, with suitable decorations and probably a verandah all round, with porches and steps. Curtains, low railings, or fretwork screens may have separated the four parties. The space must have been sufficient to accommodate at least 150 persons, the number of those whom Sulaimān Kirānī of Bengal used to entertain, and it is likely that Akbar would have provided for a much larger assembly. It is highly probable that the "cell" of Shaikh Abdu'llah, the



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disciple of Salīm Chishtī, would not have been far from the dwelling of that holy man, and consequently situated in the open space to the rear or west of the new mosque, probably a little to the north of west. As Akbar used to pass from the new "chapel" [*khankāh*], i.e. presumably part of the great mosque completed in 1571, the '*Ibādat-khāna*' apparently must have stood near the mosque, and probably was approached through a postern in the western wall of that building.

Badāonī again refers to the subject in his biography of Miyān or Shaikh Abdullah Niyāzī of Sirhind, and observes:—

"He used to remain always engaged in his religious duties in the cell close to the Shaikh's new hospice, which is now known as the royal place of worship [*'ibādat-khāna-i pādshāhī*] . . . When the Emperor rebuilt that cell which was near the Imperial palace he named it the *'ibādat-khāna* (place of worship), and, the name of Miyān Abdullah being mentioned in connection with it, he was summoned from Sirhind, and had a personal interview with the Emperor, no other person being present . . . His Majesty sent him back with honour."¹

In that passage there is nothing inconsistent with the earlier notice. It proves clearly that the *'Ibādat-khāna* was close to Shaikh Salim's quarters.

The account of Nizāmu-d dīn Ahmad is as follows:—

"The Emperor had from his early youth taken delight in the society of learned and accomplished men, and had found pleasure in the assemblies of men of imagination and genius . . . His great favour for such men led him, at the time of his return from Ajmēr in the month of Zilkāda, 982, and in the twentieth year of his reign, to issue his commands for skilful architects and clever builders to erect in the gardens of the royal palace a refuge for *sūfis*, and a home for holy men, into which none should be allowed to enter but *saiyids* of high rank, learned men (*'ulamā*), and *shaikhs*.

"In obedience to the Imperial commands, skilful architects planned a building containing four halls (*dīwān*), and in a brief period completed it. When this happy abode was finished, the Emperor used to go there on Friday nights [scil. Thursday-Friday after sunset] and on holy nights, and pass the night until the rising of the sun in the society of distinguished men.

"It was arranged that the western hall should be occupied by *saiyids*, the south by the learned (*'ulamā*) and the wise; the

¹ Ibid., vol. iii, tr. Haig, pp. 73-4, biography No. xxii. Only one fasciculus of the version of vol. iii appears to have been published. The spelling of Sirhind varies. Some authors write Sarhind or Sahrind. Raverty regarded the last-named form as the correct one.

northern by *shaikhs* and men of ecstasy (*arbāb-i-hāl*), all without confusion or intermixture. The nobles and officers of the Court, whose tastes were in unison with those of men of greatness and excellence, were to sit in the eastern hall. His Majesty graced each of the four halls with his presence, and enriched those present with his gifts and bounty . . . This assemblage used frequently to last beyond mid-day on Fridays. Sometimes, when His Majesty was tired, one of the attendants of the Court, in whose kindness and gentleness he had confidence, was deputed to perform this duty."¹

That passage brings out the additional detail that the building was erected in the gardens of the palace, and establishes beyond doubt the fact that the House of Worship was an edifice of no small size and pretensions, which needed the services of "skilful architects" to plan and of "clever builders" to erect it. No doubt, it must have been graced with abundant decoration in the rich style of which so many examples survive at Fathpur-Sikri. The passage is in no way opposed to the testimony of Badāonī. It was quite legitimate to describe the four sides as four distinct *dīvāns* or halls, because, although they were all included in one great chamber, they were severally appropriated to distinct uses, and presumably were separated by light screens, railings, or curtains of some kind, most likely of marble fretwork. Badāonī also is correct in saying that a spacious hall was built on all four sides of the modified cell.

The third author who deals with the subject is Abu-l-Fazl, who writes:—

"H.M. had in the course of seven months done the work of many years in conquering new countries, administering the old . . . and in advancing the science of worship. On the day of Ardibihisht (January 18, 1575) 8 Bahman, Divine month, he illuminated Fathpur by his presence . . . At this time when the capital (Fathpur Sikri) was illuminated by his glorious advent, H.M. ordered that a house of worship ('*Ibādat-*

¹ *Tabaqāt-i-Akbarī*, in Elliot & Dowson, v, 391.

khāna) should be built in order to the adornment of the spiritual kingdom, and that it should have four *dīwān* [Mr. Beveridge translates 'verandahs']¹ . . . He chose the eve of Friday . . . for the outpouring (*ifāzat*). A general proclamation was issued that on that night of illumination, all orders and sects of mankind—those who searched after spiritual and physical truth, and those of the common public who sought for an awakening, and the inquirers of every sect—should assemble in the precincts of the holy edifice, and bring forward their spiritual experiences, and their degrees of knowledge of the truth in various and contradictory forms in the bridal chamber of manifestation . . . To the delightful precincts of that mansion founded upon Truth, thousands upon thousands of inquirers from the seven climes came with heartfelt respect and waited for the advent of the Shāhīnshāh. . . . There were always four noble sections in that spiritual and temporal assemblage."

The author then proceeds to enumerate the four sections in bombastic terms. The people on the northern side called Shaikhs by other authors are described by Abu-l Fazl as "the Sūfis of clear heart who were absorbed in beatific visions. A few of felicitous and wide comprehensiveness which they had attained to by the bliss of H.M.'s holy instructions, lighted the torch of knowledge in all four compartments". More rhetoric follows. Little sense is to be made out of such verbiage, but we learn that in the course of time the total number of visitors mounted up to a large figure, and that a few persons were considered as qualified to sit in any one of the four sections.²

When the above passages are collated we obtain the results that the House of Worship was a large rectangular chamber built round a small structure representing a hermit's cell. The space on each side of the cell was

¹ The rendering "verandahs" is not legitimate.

² *Akbar-nāmāh*, tr. H. Beveridge, vol. iii, pp. 157-9. Mr. Beveridge has been good enough to lend me paged proofs of his third volume so far as available. The volume has not yet been published.

treated as a separate hall or section and probably was railed or curtained off from its neighbours. The building was elaborate and could accommodate a numerous company. It was situated in the gardens of the palace, near Salīm Chishtī's premises, and somewhere at the back of the great mosque, a little to the north of west, close to gardens which still exist, or existed when E. W. Smith made his admirable survey some years ago. That author found fragments of a rich circular capital, which must have belonged to an important building, "to the south of the tank abutting on the gangway leading to the large Turkish baths by the Record Chamber." That site, at the south-east corner of the royal edifices and about 300 yards a little to the north of east from the King's Gate of the great mosque, cannot be the site of the House of Worship, as suggested by E. W. Smith. The spot referred to never can have been "in the gardens of the palace", and it is not near the Chishtī premises.

Keene made the absurd suggestion that the *Diwān-i-Khāss* should be regarded as the *'Ibādat-khāna*, on account of the great central pillar, with its four stone galleries radiating from it. Those little gangways, each about 10 feet long and 2 feet wide, could not possibly be called *diwāns* or halls, nor is the *Diwān-i-Khāss* "in the gardens of the palace". Tradition, no doubt, is right in asserting that the centre of the capital of the column was Akbar's seat, "covered with silk textures and made comfortable with satin and velvet cushions," while the four ministers (the *Khān-i-khānān*, Birbal, Faizī, and Abu-l Fazl) stood at the four corners to receive orders for their respective departments.¹ Absurd though Keene's suggestion is and utterly opposed to the texts, it has got into the guidebooks, and is, I believe, commonly accepted. I repeat again, the real *'Ibādat-khāna* was a large building,

¹ Latif, *Agra*, p. 187. Mr. Havell has theories about the supposed symbolism of the richly sculptured column.

probably capable of accommodating several hundred people comfortably, with plenty of room for moving about, and situated in the palace gardens. The amount of false history current about Akbar is amazing.

The signature in September, 1579, of the Infallibility Decree which empowered Akbar to act as supreme arbiter of all questions of Muslim theology rendered vain the debates of the representatives of various schools of Muslim thought. The House of Worship was, I believe, disused from that year, and very probably was then pulled down. Its foundations may or may not exist.

The later debates, which were carried on by doctors of various religions, not by Musalmans only, seem to have been always conducted in the private apartments of the palace. They were interrupted by the Kābul campaign (February–December, 1581) and resumed for a short time after its close, in the interior of the palace (*interius atrium Regiæ*), not in the House of Worship. But nobody cared for them any longer. The attendance dwindled until the Jesuits alone were left. When they found that Akbar daily became more inclined to Hindu practices they also withdrew, and the formal set discussions came to an end.¹

¹ Monserrate, *Commentarius*, pp. 632–4.